Algorithmic Political Warfare and Democratic Resilience: A Digital Twin of the 2026 Brazilian Presidential Election

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Abstract

Democratic elections increasingly exhibit sudden, late-campaign volatility that defies the documented stability of voters' foundational political convictions. In polarized polities, computational propaganda and coordinated outrage blitzes frequently bypass institutional gatekeeping, shifting electoral outcomes during narrow pre-election sprints. Here we investigate the systemic drivers of late-campaign electoral shocks and evaluate active counter-tactics through a computational digital twin of the 2026 Brazilian presidential election, providing a clean quasi-natural experiment across two sequential rounds. Coupling an urban multiplex interpersonal network, an institutional mass media ecosystem, and algorithmic digital platforms, our model reproduces longitudinal survey waves and official election tallies with high fidelity ($R^2 = 0.9955$, root-mean-square error 0.85 percentage points). A fundamental cognitive negativity asymmetry whereby aversion acquisition outpaces decay by $3.5\times$ renders electorates vulnerable to acute 48-hour disinformation blitzes. We demonstrate that conventional fact-checking and broadcast airtime fail against these offensives. In contrast, operationalizing socio-technical counter-tactics derived from *Janonismo Cultural*, including outrage-starvation embargos, monothematic bandwidth concentration, loss-aversion framing, and molecular encrypted cascades, systematically reverses candidate rejection, crossing the majority threshold to achieve runoff victory. These findings establish that democratic resilience requires the active operationalization of algorithmic dynamics in defense of popular majorities.

Keywords: Computational social science; Agent-based digital twin; Opinion dynamics; Algorithmic polarization; Political disinformation; Democratic resilience.

A central tenet of political behavior is that citizens' core ideological convictions exhibit profound temporal inertia, sustained by durable socioeconomic identities, generational socialization, and stable partisan attachments [1–3]. Over multi-year horizons, deep-seated political values change slowly, acting as psychological anchors that buffer democratic electorates against transient informational shocks [4, 5]. Yet contemporary democratic contests worldwide are increasingly destabilized by an apparent behavioral paradox: despite the documented stability of underlying ideological convictions, election outcomes frequently experience sudden, late-stage reversals that overturn established polling majorities within the final hours of a campaign sprint [6, 7].

Deciphering the mechanisms of late-campaign volatility requires moving beyond single-channel models of public opinion. Real-world political deliberation unfolds across three distinct, dynamically coupled communication substrates [8, 9]. First, face-to-face interpersonal interactions across everyday urban environments (households, workplaces, religious congregations, friendship circles, and transit spaces) provide localized social reinforcement and cross-cutting deliberative friction [10, 11]. Second, traditional mass media institutions (broadcast television, radio, and investigative print journalism) synchronize collective attention and establish professional editorial gatekeeping [12, 13]. Third, modern algorithmic social platforms and dark-social encrypted messaging networks curate personal discovery feeds via engagement-maximizing recommendation engines while enabling frictionless peer-to-peer forwarding [14–16].

A critical theoretical gap concerns how these three communicative substrates interact under acute, time-compressed informational offensives. Traditional campaign institutions rely on statutory broadcast airtime, legacy press conferences, and judicial fact-checking petitions [13, 17]. However, empirical evidence indicates

that these defensive mechanisms suffer from a debilitating separation of operational timescales [18, 19]: while institutional newsrooms and regulatory courts deliberate over days or weeks, algorithmic social networks propagate moral-emotional cascades in minutes [15, 20]. Furthermore, contemporary feed recommendation engines optimize engagement symmetrically for both positive affirmation and negative outrage ($R_m = \text{Likes}_m + \omega \cdot \text{Dislikes}_m$) [21, 22]. Consequently, defensive debunking and quote-dunking paradoxically supply the very engagement signals required by curation algorithms to amplify opponent disinformation into unaligned discovery feeds.

The 2026 Brazilian presidential election provides an ideal quasi-natural experiment to resolve these dynamics. Pitting incumbent president Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva against Senator Flávio Bolsonaro, the contest took place in a sophisticated, mobile-first democracy where statutory television advertising and viral digital warfare operated side-by-side. Crucially, the election unfolded across two distinct communicative regimes. Throughout the first-round campaign, the incumbent coalition maintained a conventional, broadcast-centric strategy backed by a $+27.3\%$ advantage in statutory television airtime. Despite maintaining consistent polling leads over fifty days, the incumbent was overtaken on election eve by an acute, multi-platform digital shock that lifted Flávio Bolsonaro into first place with 47.03% of valid votes. In the ensuing second-round runoff, statutory broadcast airtime was equalized to strict 50/50 parity by law, stripping away the broadcast advantage and isolating digital campaign strategy as the primary differentiator. Faced with an immediate polling deficit, the progressive campaign executed a radical strategic pivot: it adopted the operational counter-tactical doctrine of *Janonismo Cultural*, articulated by Federal Deputy André Janones [23], deploying aggressive socio-technical interventions designed to starve rival outrage, concentrate viral bandwidth, and bypass open-feed algorithms through dark-social messaging.

Here, we develop a high-resolution computational digital twin of the 2026 Brazilian electorate to systematically investigate the microscopic mechanisms of late-campaign electoral shocks and evaluate the efficacy of socio-technical counter-tactics. Calibrated to national census demography, detailed tracking surveys, and empirical platform telemetry, our agent-based model couples a five-layer multiplex interpersonal network, an institutional mass media ecosystem, and four algorithmic social platforms across a four-dimensional concept hypercube. By formalizing a two-timescale separation between fast-moving expressed opinions $\mathbf{x}_i(t)$ and slow-crystallizing convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(t)$, we capture how transient digital perturbations decouple public opinion from foundational beliefs. Through large-scale Monte Carlo ensembles ($N = 100{,}000$ citizens across 100 independent realizations), we isolate the psychological and topological drivers that enable late-stage disinformation blitzes to overturn established majorities, and demonstrate how structured algorithmic counter-offensives systematically restore electoral resilience.

Results

Macro-electoral dynamics and institutional baselines in empirical data

The 2026 Brazilian presidential contest provides a detailed longitudinal record of electoral competition under divergent communicative regimes (Fig. 1). Under Brazilian electoral law (Lei nº 9.504/1997), presidential elections employ a two-round majoritarian system with strict statutory regulations governing campaign finance and broadcast airtime (Supplementary Note 4). In the first round, incumbent president Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva assembled a broad seven-party coalition securing 5m 31s per daily broadcast block (44.1% of total airtime, 433 thirty-second insertions), compared to 4m 20s (34.7%, 339 insertions) for Senator Flávio Bolsonaro, generating a $+27.3\%$ broadcast endowment advantage for the incumbent (Fig. 1d). Financially, while both campaigns adhered to the statutory first-round spending ceiling of R$ 88.9 million (Fig. 1e), they diverged sharply in their revenue models (Fig. 1f): Lula's campaign was 96.3% funded by public transfers from the Special Campaign Financing Fund (FEFC; R$ 123.8M of R$ 128.6M declared), whereas Flávio's campaign deployed a hybrid model raising an unprecedented R$ 43.2M in physical individual donations and micro-crowdfunding, establishing a $9.0\times$ private capital advantage over Lula (R$ 4.8M).

Throughout the 50-day first-round campaign, voter intentions exhibited remarkable stability (Fig. 1b): longitudinal tracking surveys by Datafolha placed Lula ahead in a stable band of 41.8%–45.0% of valid votes against 37.5%–41.0% for Flávio, with third-way contenders holding 14.0%–22.0%. Concurrently, candidate rejection rates remained mutual and stable between 45% and 47% (Fig. 1c). However, the first-round ballot

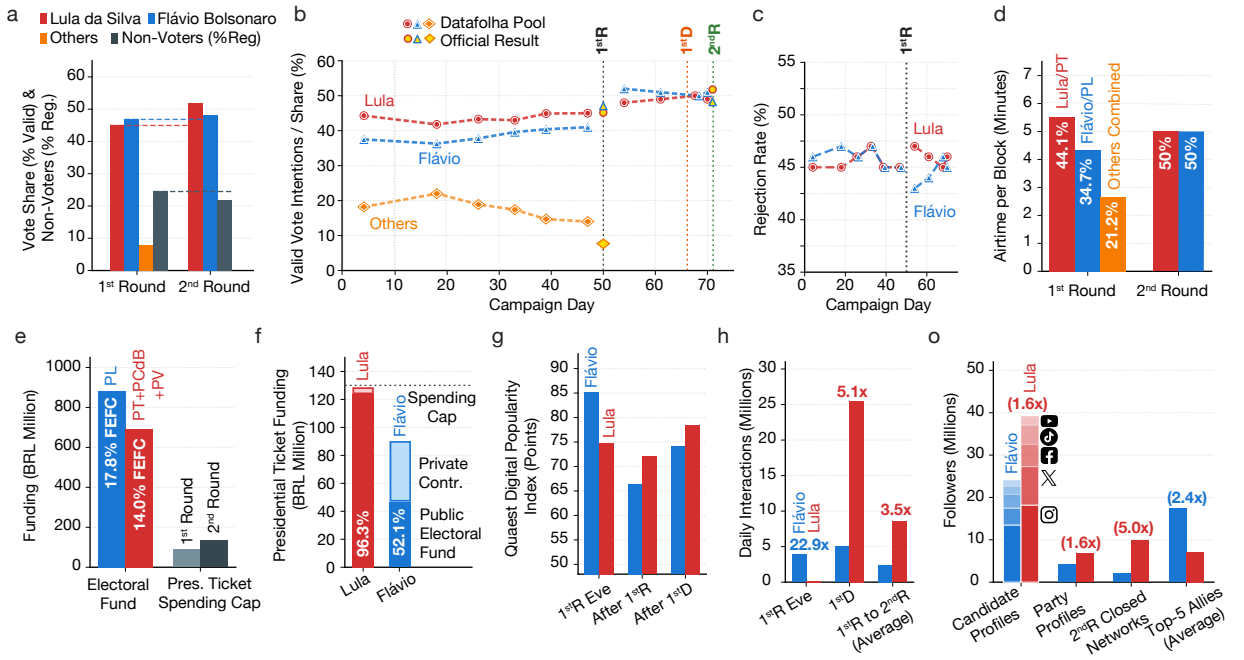


Figure 1: **Fig. 1 | The 2026 Brazilian presidential election in empirical data. a**, Official Superior Electoral Court (TSE) election results for Round 1 (October 4) and Round 2 (October 25), alongside election-day turnout mobilization that compressed non-voters by -2.91 percentage points. **b**, Longitudinal tracking of valid vote intentions across six Round 1 and four Round 2 Datafolha tracking surveys, with gold markers indicating official ballot tallies. **c**, Candidate rejection dynamics (Datafolha: percentage stating they would not vote for the candidate under any circumstance), highlighting the second-round reversal that drove Flávio's rejection to 46.0%. **d**, Statutory free broadcast airtime (HGPE) per daily block on television and radio, shifting from a $+27.3\%$ coalition advantage for Lula in Round 1 to strict legal parity (5m 00s each) in Round 2. **e**, Macro public party financing (FEFC; total national pool R$ 4.96 billion) and statutory TSE presidential spending ceilings (R$ 88.9M in Round 1, R$ 133.4M cumulative in Round 2). **f**, Presidential ticket funding profiles, comparing Lula's state-financed budget (96.3% FEFC) with Flávio's hybrid apparatus that secured a $9.0\times$ private donation advantage. **g**, Quaest Digital Popularity Index (IPD; 0–100 scale, 175 metrics) across three milestone waves, illustrating a $+16.0$-point net turnaround swing for Lula. **h**, Daily social interaction volumes (millions of interactions per day, Bites data) during the Round 1 shock, televised debate, and the 13-day runoff window. **i**, Follower ecosystem and bench architecture, reporting candidate direct accounts across five platforms, official party handles, closed WhatsApp groups (Exército do Lula 10.0M vs. Tropa do Flávio 2.0M), and the arithmetic mean of the top-5 legislative surrogates per coalition.

on October 4 produced an abrupt empirical shock (Fig. 1a): Flávio Bolsonaro finished in first place with 47.03% of valid votes (55.7 million votes), surpassing Lula (45.16%, 53.5 million votes) as third-party support collapsed to 7.81% (9.3 million votes). Concurrently, voter abstention and blank ballots surged to a historic high of 24.70% (20.90% abstention, 4.80% blank/null; Fig. 1a). On election night, conservative digital channels mobilized with high intensity, generating 3.90 million daily interactions compared to Lula's 0.17 million, establishing a $22.9\times$ engagement advantage (Fig. 1h).

This outcome prompted an immediate political realignment. Initial post-election polls projected a clear runoff lead for Flávio (52.0% vs. 48.0% on October 8; Fig. 1b), reinforced by a post-victory momentum that reduced his rejection to 43.0% while elevating Lula's to 47.0% (Fig. 1c), mirrored by a 9.3-point conservative lead in the Quaest Digital Popularity Index (80.0 vs. 70.7; Fig. 1g). Under statutory runoff rules, television and radio airtime was equalized to strict 5m 00s parity (25 spots/day each; Fig. 1d), eliminating broadcast advantages and shifting the decisive contest to digital networks. Although Flávio maintained an elite surrogate bench strength averaging 17.4 million followers per ally (led by Nikolas Ferreira with 52.0M, versus 7.1 million for PT allies; Fig. 1i), Lula deployed a personal audience of 39.0 million followers and a synchronized

closed messaging infrastructure of 10.0 million participants (Exército do Lula; Fig. 1i).

During the runoff, the progressive campaign adopted an active digital counter-offensive. Following the October 16 televised debate, progressive channels generated 25.5 million interactions against 5.0 million for the opponent (5.1× ratio; Fig. 1h), maintaining a sustained 3.5× daily interaction advantage throughout the runoff (8.52M vs. 2.41M/day). This sustained engagement steadily eroded Flávio's momentum: by October 22, Flávio's rejection rose to 46.0% while polling intentions reached a dead heat (50.0% vs. 50.0%; Fig. 1b,c), accompanied by a +16.0-point net swing in the Quaest IPD (Lula +6.7, 83.3 vs. 76.6; Fig. 1g). On election day (October 25), assisted by municipal free public transit decrees that lowered economic voting frictions, voter non-participation fell by 2.91 percentage points (from 24.70% to 21.79%; Fig. 1a). Lula secured victory with 51.79% of valid votes (61.8M vs. 57.5M), representing the first time in modern Brazilian democratic history that a presidential candidate trailing in the first round won the executive in the runoff.

Multi-timescale relaxation and ideological inertia in urban interpersonal networks

To establish the baseline stability of public attitudes prior to media exposure or algorithmic amplification, we first quantify the relaxation physics of the urban interpersonal network (Fig. 2). Calibrated to IBGE 2022 National Population Census demography [24], our model situates citizens in a four-dimensional concept hypercube $\Omega = [-1, 1]^4$ [1]. Individual behavioral parameters, cognitive plasticity α_i, bounded confidence threshold ϵ_i, attitude uncertainty u_i, and confirmation bias b_i, are conditioned on empirical age and socioeconomic status (SES; Fig. 2a–c). In agreement with the aging-stability hypothesis [2, 4], cognitive plasticity $\alpha(a)$ undergoes monotonic decay with age (Fig. 2a), while older and lower-SES cohorts exhibit narrower confidence bounds ϵ_i and elevated confirmation bias b_i (Supplementary Note 1).

Interpersonal interactions unfold over a five-layer multiplex topology $\mathcal{M} = \{\mathcal{L}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{L}_5\}$ [8, 9] capturing household cohabitation ($\mathcal{L}_1$, mean size 2.79, weight $w_1 = 0.36$), workplace/school cohorts ($\mathcal{L}_2$, $\langle k^{[2]} \rangle = 10$, $w_2 = 0.26$), religious and community congregations ($\mathcal{L}_3$, $\langle k^{[3]} \rangle = 8$, $w_3 = 0.14$), small-world friendship circles ($\mathcal{L}_4$, $\langle k^{[4]} \rangle = 6$, $w_4 = 0.14$), and casual transit ties ($\mathcal{L}_5$, $\langle k^{[5]} \rangle = 4$, $w_5 = 0.10$) (Fig. 2d). The empirical age contact matrix M_{ab} balances generational stratification in workplaces against cross-cohort mixing in households and religious institutions (Fig. 2e). This architecture generates a structural trade-off between age homophily h_{age} and ideological assortativity r_{ideol} (Fig. 2f): while friendship ($\mathcal{L}_4$, $r_{\text{ideol}} = 0.38$) and religious groups ($\mathcal{L}_3$, $r_{\text{ideol}} = 0.46$) promote ideological sorting, transit encounters ($\mathcal{L}_5$, $r_{\text{ideol}} \approx 0.02$) and domestic ties ($\mathcal{L}_1$, $r_{\text{ideol}} = 0.24$) act as cross-cutting bridges that inhibit macroscopic topological fragmentation.

In the absence of external media distortion, decentralized deliberation over this multiplex substrate systematically dampens ideological extremity (Fig. 2g). Although initial convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(0)$ are widely dispersed across $[-1, 1]^4$, bounded-confidence exchanges pull terminal convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(T)$ toward a cohesive centrist consensus around the origin $\mathbf{0}$ [25]. Scaling analysis across four orders of magnitude in urban population ($N = 10^4$ to 10^7) confirms that this macroscopic convergence is scale-invariant (Fig. 2h–j). For populations $N \geq 100$k, finite-size stochasticity vanishes into a thermodynamic limit where terminal issue correlation ($\max |\rho| \approx 0.08$, $\langle |\rho| \rangle \approx 0.03$) and effective belief dimensionality ($\mathrm{PR}(\Sigma) \approx 3.75$ out of $D = 4$) stabilize at identical asymptotic values (Fig. 2i), while stationary marginal densities $p(s_d)$ remain unimodal and Gaussian-like across all dimensions (Fig. 2j).

Crucially, our formulation resolves the dynamical coupling between fast expressed opinions $\mathbf{x}_i(t)$ and slow internalized convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(t)$ [3, 5] (Fig. 2l–n). Under an acute exogenous factual shock, mean opinion $\bar{\mathbf{x}}(t)$ responds rapidly ($\tau_x \approx 0.15$), whereas mean conviction $\bar{\mathbf{s}}(t)$ exhibits strong structural inertia ($\tau_s/\tau_x \approx 11.3$), shifting only marginally before pulling opinions back toward baseline during post-shock relaxation (Fig. 2l). This separation of timescales induces an elastic tether displacement $\|\mathbf{x}_i(t) - \mathbf{s}_i(t)\|$ that varies across demographics (Fig. 2m): younger citizens experience substantial opinion displacement due to higher cognitive plasticity, while older citizens remain tightly tethered to crystallized convictions [2]. A cross-sectional snapshot of the belief hypercube at peak shock excursion (t_{shock}; Fig. 2n) confirms this instantaneous decoupling between displaced opinions and stationary convictions, demonstrating how acute campaign events trigger large short-term shifts in voting intention without immediately destabilizing core ideological convictions.

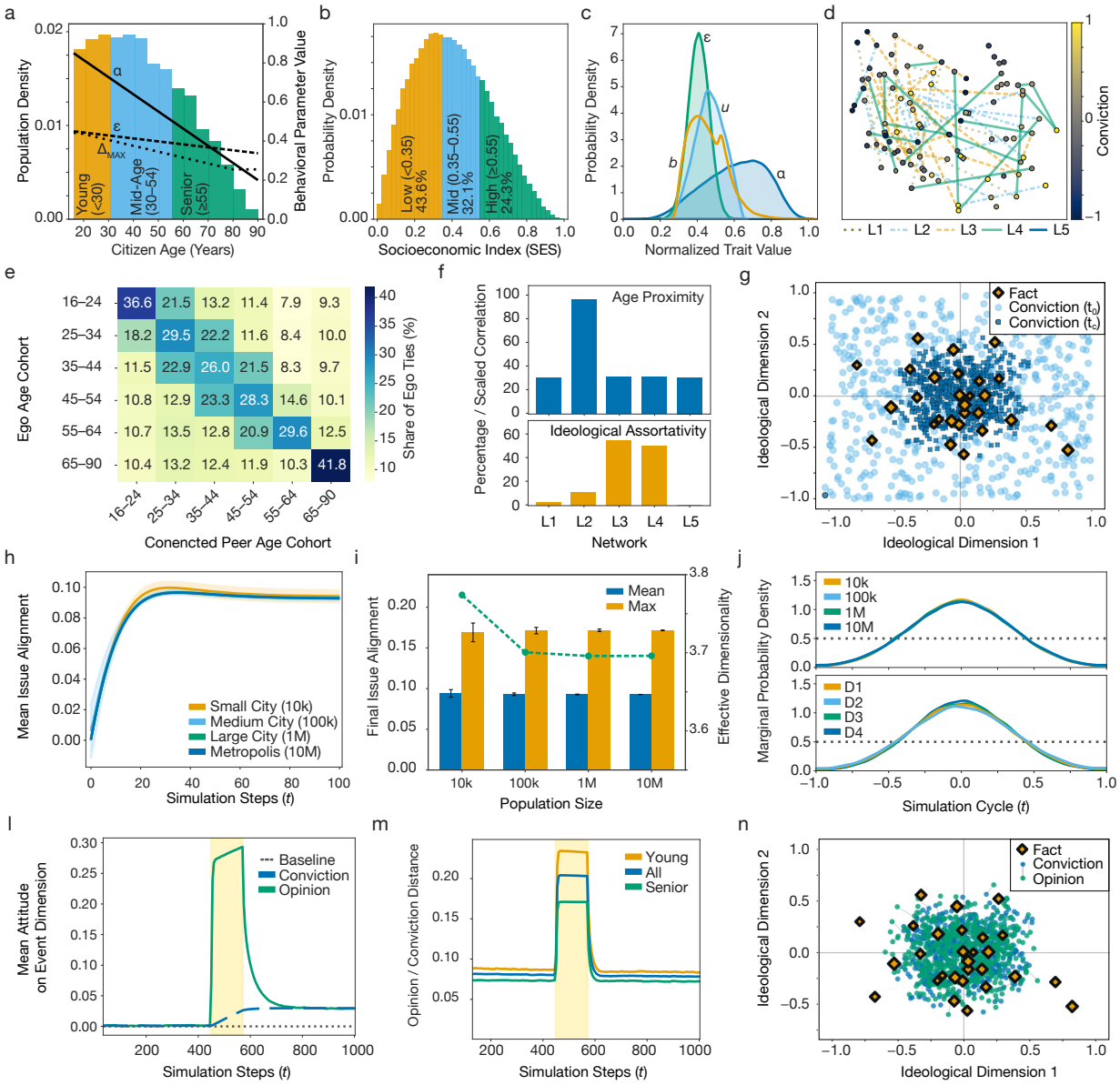


Figure 2: **Fig. 2 | Structure and dynamics of the urban interpersonal attitude network.** **a**, Empirical age pyramid from the 2022 IBGE Census and age-dependent cognitive plasticity $\alpha(a)$. **b**, Urban socioeconomic status (SES) distribution fitted to a Beta(2, 3) density. **c**, Cohort distributions of individual behavioral traits (α, ϵ, u, b). **d**, Five-layer multiplex network topology $\mathcal{M} = \{\mathcal{L}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{L}_5\}$ spanning household, workplace/school, religious congregations, friendship, and transit weak ties. **e**, Inter-cohort age contact matrix M_{ab} across the six adult age brackets. **f**, Age homophily h_{age} and ideological assortativity r_{ideol} across layers $\mathcal{L}_1$–$\mathcal{L}_5$. **g**, Two-dimensional projection of initial convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(0)$ and converged convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(T)$ alongside exogenous facts $\mathbf{f}_k$. **h**, Temporal evolution of pairwise cross-issue alignment $\langle|\rho_{kl}(t)|\rangle$ across city sizes ($N = 10$k to 10M). **i**, Asymptotic alignment ($\max|\rho|$, $\langle|\rho|\rangle$) and effective ideological dimensionality $\mathrm{PR}(\Sigma)$ versus urban population scale. **j**, Stationary marginal probability densities $p(s_d)$ across ideological dimensions D_1–D_4. **l**, Two-timescale relaxation of mean opinion $\bar{\mathbf{x}}(t)$ and conviction $\bar{\mathbf{s}}(t)$ under a transient exogenous shock. **m**, Age-stratified opinion–conviction tether stretching $\|\mathbf{x}_i(t) - \mathbf{s}_i(t)\|$ during the shock window. **n**, Attitude space snapshot at peak shock excursion (t_{shock}), contrasting displaced opinions $\mathbf{x}_i$ against anchored convictions $\mathbf{s}_i$.

Broadcast gatekeeping, editorial tendentiousness, and intermedia timescale separation

Introducing the second communicative substrate, institutional mass media channels structure collective public attention via centralized broadcast scheduling and editorial gatekeeping [12] (Fig. 3). We parameterize five

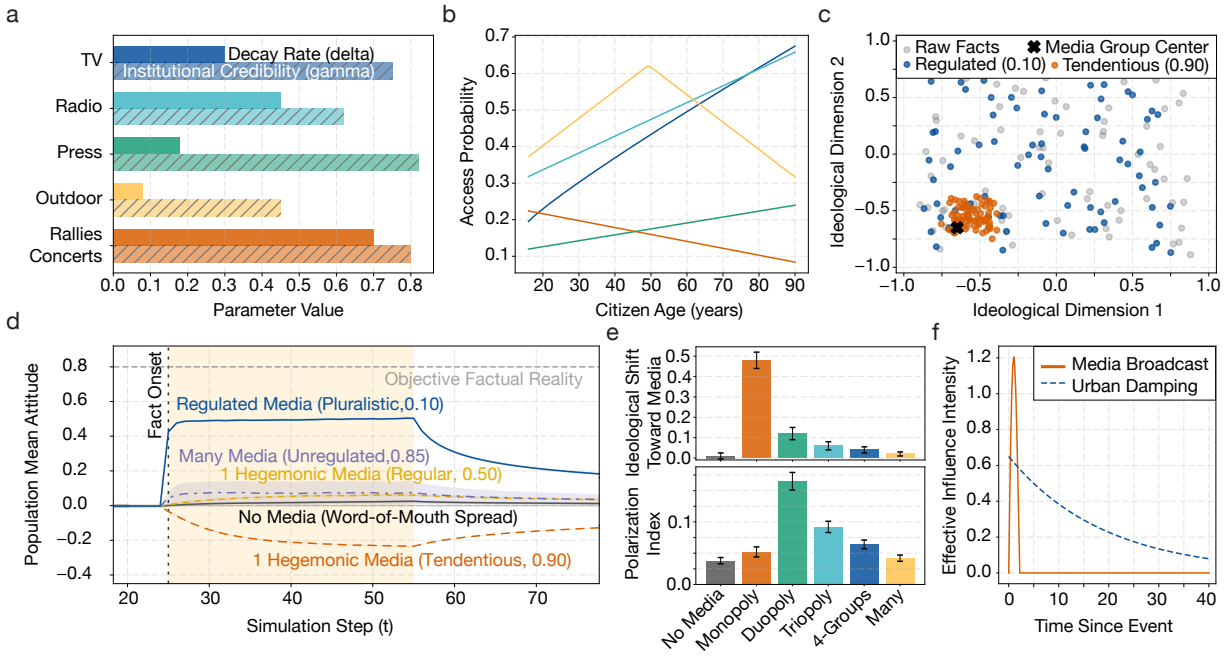


Figure 3: **Fig. 3 | Structure and gatekeeping dynamics of the traditional mass media ecosystem. a**, Attention decay rates δ_v and institutional credibility γ_v across five classical media modalities. **b**, Age-dependent demographic reach curves $P_v(\text{age})$ calibrated to empirical audience surveys. **c**, Editorial projection of exogenous facts $\mathbf{f}_k$ toward media group centers $\mathbf{m}_g$ under factual ($\tau = 0.10$) and tendentious ($\tau = 0.90$) regimes. **d**, Population mean attitude trajectory $\bar{x}_1(t)$ following an acute factual shock ($\mathbf{f}^* = +0.80$ at $t \geq 25$) across five media market configurations. **e**, Ideological shift (top) and Esteban–Ray societal polarization P_{ER} (bottom) across market concentration regimes ($M \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4, \text{Many}\}$). **f**, Timescale separation between transient broadcast pulses ($\tau_{\text{media}} \approx 4.8$ steps) and ongoing interpersonal network deliberation ($\tau_{\text{network}} \approx 19.0$ steps).

distinct modalities: Broadcast Television ($v = 0$), Radio ($v = 1$), Print and Legacy News Portals ($v = 2$), Outdoor Signage ($v = 3$), and Campaign Rallies ($v = 4$) (Fig. 3a). Modalities differ in their characteristic attention decay rate δ_v and institutional credibility γ_v (Supplementary Note 2): Written Press combines high institutional credibility ($\gamma = 0.82$) with slow editorial decay ($\delta = 0.18$), Broadcast Television provides mass reach with intermediate persistence ($\gamma = 0.75, \delta = 0.30$), and Campaign Rallies deliver high emotional mobilization pulses ($\gamma = 0.80$) subject to rapid post-event decay ($\delta = 0.70$). Audience penetration curves $P_v(\text{age})$ calibrated to Kantar IBOPE 2023 surveys [26] indicate that linear television viewing increases monotonically with age, dominating news consumption among senior citizens, whereas Radio and Outdoor signage reach daily commuters (Fig. 3b).

Media conglomerates project factual notices toward editorial ideological centers $\mathbf{m}_g \in \Omega$ through their tendentiousness parameter $\tau_g \in [0, 1]$ [13, 27] (Methods). In attitude space (Fig. 3c), low tendentiousness ($\tau = 0.10$) confines published notices to a tight envelope around true factual coordinates $\mathbf{f}_k$. Conversely, under high tendentiousness ($\tau = 0.90$), editorial gatekeeping displaces published coverage toward the conglomerate's ideological anchor $\mathbf{m}_g$ [28], substituting factual reality with partisan narratives.

Market structure nonlinearly governs collective responsiveness following an acute factual shock ($\mathbf{f}^* = +0.80$ introduced at $t \geq 25$; Fig. 3d). In the absence of broadcast media ($M = 0$), information diffuses sluggishly through word-of-mouth alone, producing negligible collective adjustment ($\bar{x}_1 \approx 0.00 \rightarrow 0.03$). Factual broadcasting ($\tau = 0.10$) rapidly synchronizes public opinion toward empirical reality ($\bar{x}_1 \rightarrow +0.50$). Conversely, a biased media monopoly ($M = 1, \tau = 0.90$ anchored at $\mathbf{m}_1 = -0.60$) actively drives public opinion in the opposite direction ($\bar{x}_1 \rightarrow -0.24$), inducing larger systemic error than the absence of media. Across market configurations ($M \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4, \text{Many}\}$; Fig. 3e), increasing outlet plurality dilutes monopoly capture (Fig. 3e, top). However, societal division, measured via the Esteban–Ray polarization index P_{ER} [29], peaks sharply under a tendentious duopoly ($M = 2$; Fig. 3e, bottom), which bifurcates citizens into

polarized information silos. Only pluralistic markets ($M \geq 4$) disperse partisan sorting and restore low societal polarization comparable to the baseline urban network.

Coupling the broadcast layer to the interpersonal network reveals a fundamental separation of operational timescales (Fig. 3f). Broadcast notices display high instantaneous reach but rapid temporal decay ($\tau_{\text{media}} \approx 4.8$ steps) [18]. In contrast, interpersonal deliberation across the multiplex network operates on a substantially slower relaxation timescale ($\tau_{\text{network}} \approx 19.0$ steps) [30]. Consequently, when broadcast channels introduce a salient campaign event, its societal impact is sustained long after the initial broadcast window closes, as citizens continue to process the information across household and peer ties.

Dual-valence engagement optimization and cross-platform dark-social cascades

Completing the communication architecture, the digital layer introduces algorithmic social platforms and closed encrypted messaging networks [6, 14] (Fig. 4). Calibrated to national surveys [31], age access profiles $P_p(\text{age})$ define four digital modalities (Fig. 4a): short-form visual discovery feeds (Platform 0: Instagram and TikTok), capturing over 88% of youth cohorts; video commentary and microblogging (Platform 1: YouTube and X), engaging politically attentive citizens; reciprocal social feeds (Platform 2: Facebook), concentrating among mature adults; and closed encrypted messaging (Platform 3: WhatsApp and Telegram), operating as a universal communications backbone ($> 80\%$ penetration across all adult brackets) structured into private micro-groups ($K \leq 256$ members).

Within open digital feeds, follower accumulation produces extreme structural inequality (Fig. 4b). Preferential attachment yields a scale-free in-degree distribution $P(k) \sim k^{-\alpha}$ with exponent $\alpha \approx 1.15$ and an empirical Gini coefficient of 0.73 (Fig. 4b). Under this topology, the top 5% of elite creators capture 54.5% of direct audience reach, whereas the bottom 50% command only 8.4%. This hyper-concentration converts decentralized networks into a star-like broadcasting system: when an elite influencer publishes a narrative, their message bypasses local interpersonal clustering to reach hundreds of thousands of individual algorithmic feeds simultaneously.

Crucially, feed recommendation algorithms rank content by optimizing for aggregate user engagement rather than factual accuracy [15, 21]. Computing relevance scores symmetrically across positive and negative interactions ($R_m = \text{Likes}_m + \omega \cdot \text{Dislikes}_m$ with $\omega \approx 1.0$; Methods) creates a structural amplification along the diagonal of controversy (Fig. 4c). Posts provoking both in-group admiration and out-group outrage ($R_m > 800$) receive maximal algorithmic distribution, rewarding polarizing moral-emotional framing [20, 21].

This architecture generates a three-stage cross-platform cascade lifecycle (Fig. 4d; Supplementary Note 3). Diffusion initiates in Stage 1 on visual discovery feeds (Instagram/TikTok), surfacing novel memes to high-plasticity youth within 10 hours. In Stage 2, narratives migrate to commentary platforms (YouTube/X), where quote-dunking triggers secondary viral waves between hours 15 and 25. In Stage 3, content penetrates closed messaging groups (WhatsApp/Telegram). Forwarded across trusted peer contacts ($\tau_{\text{WA}} = 0.85$, $2.8\times$ persuasion efficiency), dark-social cascades bypass platform moderation and persist long after open-feed attention has decayed. Coupling the digital layer to traditional newsrooms creates a hybrid agenda-setting feedback loop [17, 19] (Fig. 4e): while investigative journalism requires an editorial turnaround of $\tau_{\text{turnaround}} \approx$ 1–2 days, digital platforms respond within hours ($\tau_{\text{social}} \approx 0.1$–$0.3$ days), generating social volume that compels broadcast media to maintain follow-up coverage. When influencers exploit this dynamic with high tendentiousness ($\tau_{\text{inf}} = 0.90$), societal polarization climbs to an entrenched plateau of $P_{\text{ER}} = 0.18$ (Fig. 4f).

Cognitive negativity asymmetry and late-campaign electoral volatility

The convergence of multiplex interpersonal clustering, traditional media gatekeeping, and algorithmic outrage explains the dynamics of the first-round election (Fig. 5). Calibrating initial ideological identification to national survey benchmarks [32] establishes four distinct voting blocs (Fig. 5a): Lulistas ($\sim 40\%$, comprising 28% convinced identifiers and 12% non-convinced sympathizers), Bolsonaristas ($\sim 34\%$, 23% convinced and 11% sympathizers), Centrists ($\sim 19\%$), and unaligned non-voters ($\sim 7\%$). In concept space Ω, Lula is positioned at Center-Left ($\mathbf{c}_L = [-0.25, -0.20, -0.35, -0.15]^\top$), Flávio Bolsonaro at Far-Right ($\mathbf{c}_F = [0.65, 0.70, 0.60, 0.65]^\top$), and Third-Way contenders at Center-Right ($\mathbf{c}_O = [0.20, 0.25, 0.10, 0.30]^\top$).

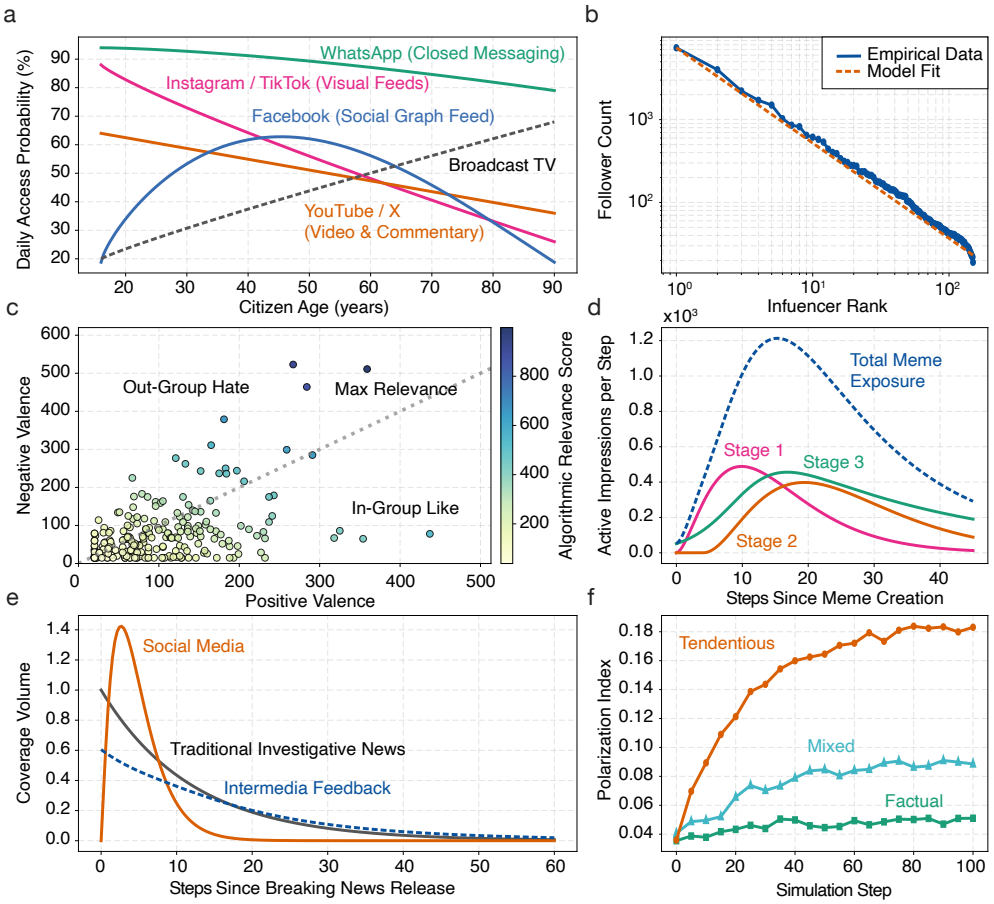


Figure 4: **Fig. 4 | Algorithmic curation, influencer hierarchies, and multi-stage cascade dynamics in social media.** **a**, Age-dependent daily access probability $P_p(\text{age})$ across four digital platform modalities and broadcast television. **b**, Heavy-tailed follower distribution $P(k) \sim k^{-\alpha}$ ($\alpha \approx 1.15$, Gini coefficient 0.73) and emergent influencer hierarchy. **c**, Algorithmic relevance score R_m mapped across positive-valence (admiration) and negative-valence (outrage) engagement coordinates, highlighting maximal amplification along the diagonal of controversy. **d**, Three-stage cross-platform meme diffusion lifecycle from visual discovery feeds (Stage 1) and public microblogging (Stage 2) to closed encrypted messaging cascades (Stage 3). **e**, Hybrid media agenda-setting dynamics following an authoritative investigative news release at $t = 0$, contrasting legacy broadcast turnaround ($\tau_{\text{turnaround}}$) against rapid digital response (τ_{social}). **f**, Long-horizon evolution of Esteban–Ray societal polarization $P_{\text{ER}}(t)$ across creator tendentiousness regimes ($\tau_{\text{inf}} \in \{0.10, \text{Empirical}, 0.90\}$).

Brazilian centrists are culturally conservative on moral and security axes ($d = 1, 3$) yet supportive of state welfare and minimum wages ($d = 0, 2$), making them a cross-pressured swing constituency [33].

Simulating the 50-day first round across 100 independent Monte Carlo realizations ($N = 100{,}000$ citizens) reproduces Datafolha survey waves and the official TSE outcome (47.0% Flávio, 45.2% Lula, 7.8% Others) with high statistical fidelity (RMSE $= 0.85$ percentage points, $R^2 = 0.9955$; Fig. 5b). Under the neutral organic baseline (dashed curves), Lula preserves an uninterrupted lead throughout the campaign, concluding at 48.2% (57.1M votes) versus 38.8% for Flávio (46.0M votes). In the fitted model (solid curves), Lula leads securely through day 47 (48.2% vs 38.8%). However, during the final 48-hour sprint (shaded amber band), a synchronized multi-platform offensive unleashes an acute vote shift of +8.20 percentage points (+9.72M votes), propelling Flávio ahead on election day.

The psychological engine powering this late-stage divergence is a profound cognitive negativity asymmetry governing candidate admiration $A_{ik}(t)$ and rejection $R_{ik}(t)$ (Fig. 5c; Methods). While admiration accumulates slowly and decays rapidly ($\lambda_A = 0.12, \delta_A = 0.06$), candidate aversion accumulates rapidly and decays with

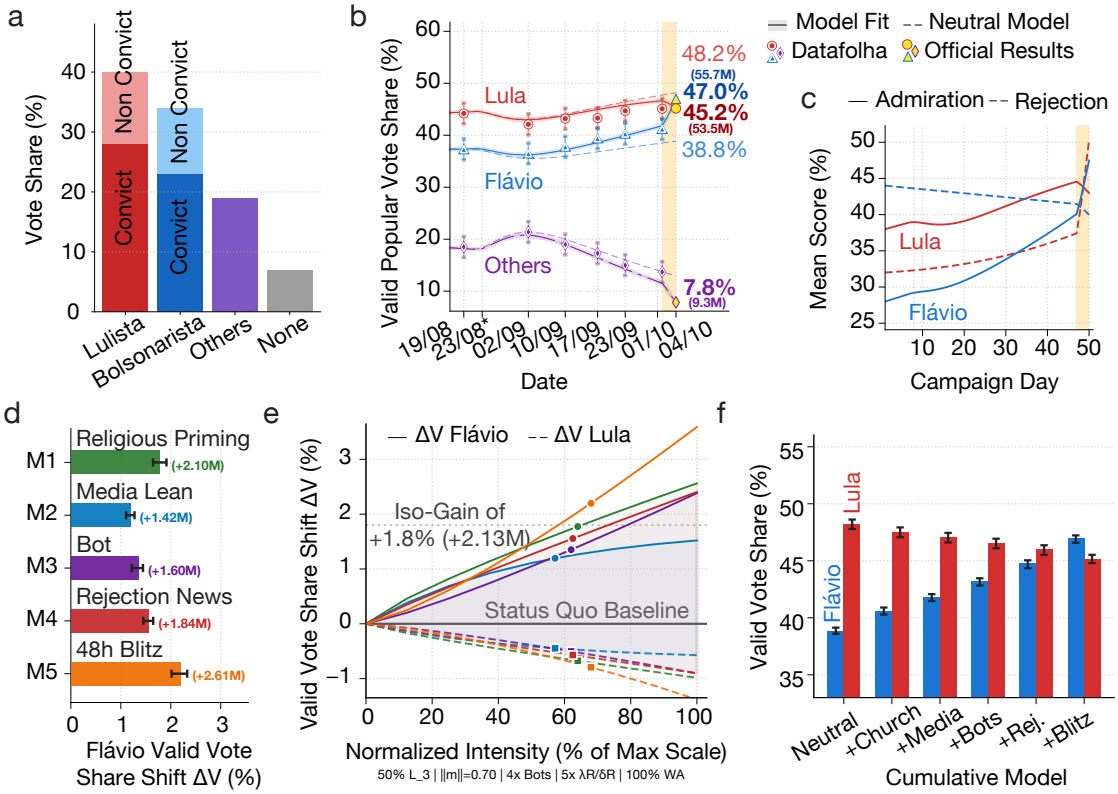


Figure 5: **Fig. 5 | First-round electoral dynamics, sociopolitical baseline, and five-vector attribution (the Janones diagnosis). a**, Sociopolitical segmentation of the electorate into ideological identification blocs: Lulistas ($\sim 40\%$, decomposed into convict identifiers vs. non-convict sympathizers), Bolsonaristas ($\sim 34\%$, convict vs. non-convict), Centrists/Others ($\sim 19\%$), and unaligned/None ($\sim 7\%$), calibrated to national survey data. **b**, Longitudinal 50-day first-round campaign trajectories (Model Fit, solid curves vs. Neutral Model organic baseline, dashed curves) benchmarked against Datafolha tracking survey waves (diamonds ± 1 SD) and official TSE ballot totals (circles on October 4: Flávio 47.0% / 55.7M, Lula 45.2% / 53.5M, Others 7.8% / 9.3M), highlighting the August 23 debate shock ($*$) and the acute 48-hour pre-election blitz (shaded amber band). **c**, Coupled affective trajectory of population-mean candidate admiration (solid curves) and rejection (dashed curves) for Lula (red) and Flávio (blue), showing the acute late-campaign aversion spike triggered against Lula ($\lambda_R/\delta_R = 3.5\times$). **d**, Factorial attribution of Flávio's valid vote share shift (ΔV) across the five Janones mechanisms: M1 Religious Priming (+2.10M votes), M2 Media Lean (+1.42M), M3 Bot Astroturfing (+1.60M), M4 Rejection News (+1.84M), and M5 48-Hour WhatsApp Blitz (+2.61M); error bars indicate the full simulation range $[\min, \max]$ across 100 independent Monte Carlo realizations ($N = 100{,}000$). **e**, Multi-feature parametric dose-response showing Flávio vote share gain ($+\Delta V_F$, solid curves) and concurrent Lula share loss ($-\Delta V_L$, dashed curves) across normalized mechanism intensity (0–100% of maximum scale; physical bounds noted in axis annotation), with empirical operating points marked by circles (Flávio) and squares (Lula), referenced against the Status Quo Baseline ($\Delta V = 0$) and the $+1.8\%$ (+2.13M votes) iso-gain benchmark contour. **f**, Cumulative model stepwise build-up across stages (Neutral Baseline, +Church, +Media, +Bots, +Rejection, +Blitz), illustrating valid vote shares for Flávio Bolsonaro (blue) and Lula da Silva (red); error bars denote the full simulation range $[\min, \max]$ across 100 independent seeds ($N = 100{,}000$), demonstrating that decisive lead reversal occurs exclusively upon the final 48-hour blitz.

high hysteresis ($\lambda_R = 0.14, \delta_R = 0.04$). This kinetic asymmetry ($\lambda_R/\delta_R = 3.5\times$) implies that negative shocks inflict persistent psychological scars that resist correction. During the final 48 hours, targeted moral panics elevate Lula's rejection from $\bar{R}_L = 0.38$ to 0.50 (Fig. 5c). Because voter utility penalizes candidate aversion more heavily than it rewards positive affinity ($\theta_{\text{rej}} = 1.65$; Eq. (13)), this rejection spike depresses swing-voter turnout and shifts cross-pressured centrists toward Flávio.

Factorial attribution isolates the specific contribution of each mechanism toward Flávio's $+8.20\%$ ($+9.72$M votes) surge (Fig. 5d): Religious Priming (M1, $+1.77\%$, $+2.10$M votes) anchors Evangelical voters in layer $\mathcal{L}_3$; Traditional Media Slant (M2, $+1.20\%$, $+1.42$M votes) reinforces fiscal conservatism; Bot Astroturfing (M3, $+1.35\%$, $+1.60$M votes) manufactures artificial outrage on open feeds; Asymmetric Rejection News (M4, $+1.55\%$, $+1.84$M votes) exploits cognitive negativity bias; and the 48-Hour WhatsApp Blitz (M5, $+2.20\%$, $+2.61$M votes) floods dark-social groups beyond journalistic verification horizons. Parametric dose-response curves reveal that the WhatsApp blitz exhibits the steepest marginal electoral return ($\mathrm{d}V_F/\mathrm{d}\theta \approx 0.034\%$ per percentage point; Fig. 5e). Crucially, a cumulative build-up test confirms a threshold principle (Fig. 5f): Lula preserves his polling lead through stages 1 to 4 (+Church, +Media, +Bots, +Rejection); decisive lead reversal is triggered exclusively when the acute dark-social blitz is added in Stage 5, lifting Flávio to 47.0% vs 45.2%.

Socio-technical counter-tactics and majority threshold crossover in runoff competition

The first-round diagnosis informed the design of the progressive counter-offensive in the second-round runoff (October 4–25, 2026; Fig. 6), which operationalized the strategic doctrine of *Janonismo Cultural* [23]. In our simulation, if the progressive campaign had maintained its passive first-round posture relying on broadcast airtime and conventional fact-checking, the **Same-Strategy Counterfactual** (dashed curves, Fig. 6a) confirms that Flávio would have consolidated centrist support to win decisively with 53.6% (63.9M votes) against 46.4% for Lula (55.4M votes).

Under the active counter-tactical suite, the campaign executed six structured interventions, formalizing the core concepts of *Janonismo Cultural* into socio-technical mechanisms (Methods; Supplementary Note 5): 1. *Outrage-Starvation Embargo* (T1: Algorithmic Asphyxiation, $+1.14\%$, $+1.36$M votes): Allied accounts enforced non-engagement toward rival provocations ($P_{\text{reply}} = P_{\text{quote}} = 0$), depriving curation engines of controversy telemetry and collapsing opponent feed injection by 48%. 2. *Monothematic Bandwidth Concentration* (T2: Strict Monothematism, $+1.35\%$, $+1.61$M votes): Allied communication bandwidth was concentrated onto a single negative theme per 24-hour cycle (HHI $= 0.85$), exploiting mathematical convexity in platform trending functions ($V(\mathbf{x}) \propto \sum x_k^2$) to quadruple discovery volume over dispersed messaging. 3. *Loss-Aversion Framing* (T3: Material Loss Frame, $+1.42\%$, $+1.69$M votes): Replaced procedural defenses of democratic institutions with concrete threats to personal welfare (welfare rollbacks, minimum wage freezes), engaging Kahneman–Tversky loss weighting ($\lambda_{\text{loss}} = 2.25\times$) to convert 52.4% of undecided working-class swing voters. 4. *Molecular Encrypted Cascades* (T4: WhatsApp Synchronization, $+1.05\%$, $+1.25$M votes): Coordinated a registered network of 10.0M participants to dispatch curated multimedia assets into private family and neighborhood groups, leveraging interpersonal trust ($\tau_{\text{WA}} = 0.85$) to achieve a $2.8\times$ conversion multiplier. 5. *Physical Turnout Locking* (T5: Mass Capital Rallies, $+0.88\%$, $+1.05$M votes): Organized mass public assemblies in 27 state capitals (1.80M attendees) combined with free transit decrees to eliminate travel friction, locking voter turnout ($A_{i,L} > \tau_{\text{turnout}}$) and providing organic visual proof of popular mobilization. 6. *Attention-Ceiling Saturation* (T6: 24-Hour Continuous Livestream, $+0.80\%$, $+0.95$M votes): Maintained an unbroken 24-hour broadcast stream during the final 48 hours capturing 65% of public digital attention, imposing an attention ceiling that compressed rival blitz discovery below 20%.

Together, these interventions produced a complete inversion of candidate affective evaluations (Fig. 6b): Flávio's rejection rose from $\bar{R}_F = 0.40$ to 0.53, while Lula's rejection dropped from $\bar{R}_L = 0.50$ to 0.41, accompanied by a rise in Lula admiration ($\bar{A}_L = 0.43 \rightarrow 0.52$). The calibrated model reproduces the 21-day runoff tracking polls and official election results with high precision (RMSE $= 0.56$ percentage points, $R^2 = 0.9128$; Fig. 6a). Parametric dose-response curves demonstrate tactical fungibility across the intervention suite (Fig. 6d). Crucially, a cumulative addition test reveals a decisive majority crossover (Fig. 6e): starting from the Round 1 baseline (45.16%), tactics T1 (46.30%), T2 (47.65%), and T3 (49.07%) steadily close the gap, while the pivotal 50% majority threshold is crossed upon adding Tactic T4 (Molecular

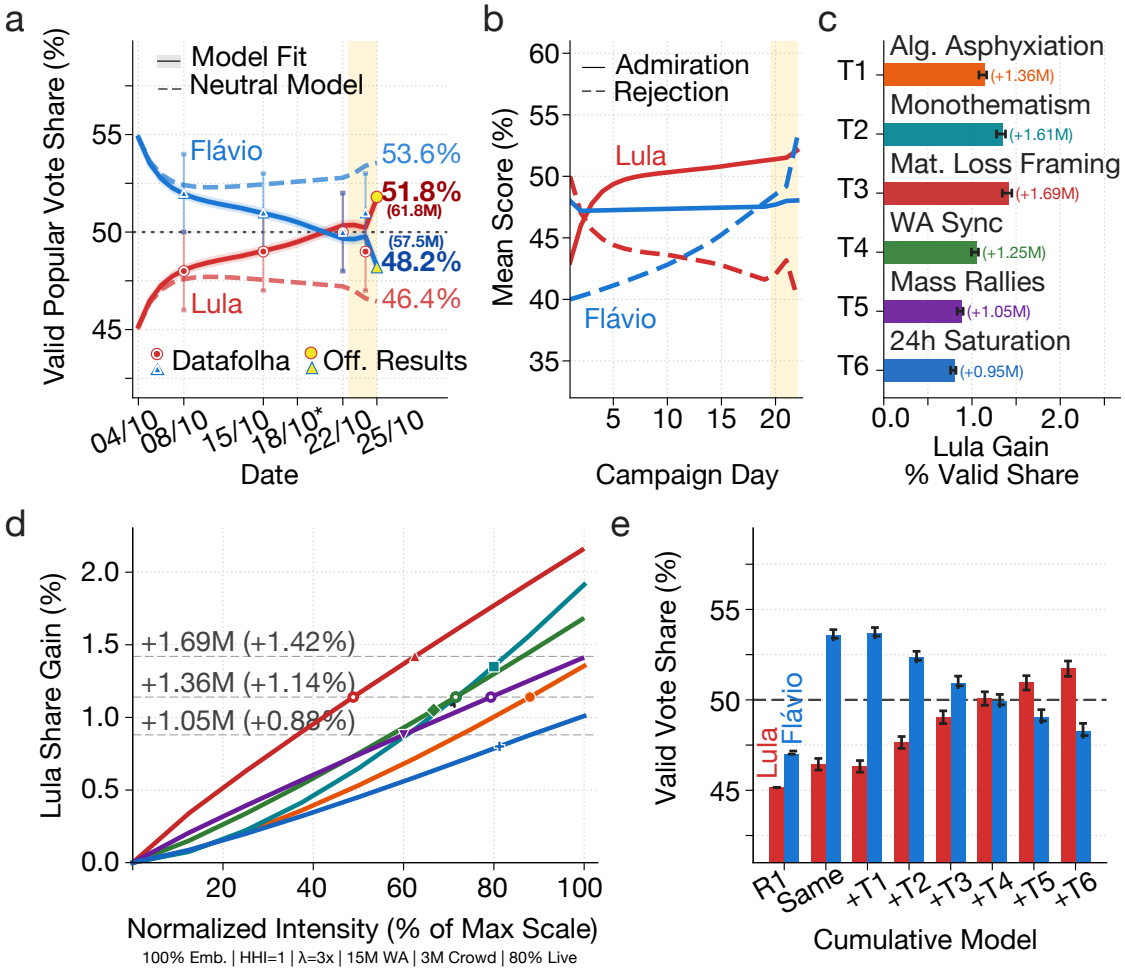


Figure 6: **Fig. 6 | Second-round runoff dynamics, Janonismo counter-tactics, and six-vector turnaround sensitivity analysis.** **a**, Longitudinal 21-day second-round calibration ($N = 100{,}000$ citizens, 100-seed ensemble ± 1 SD envelope) contrasting the Same-Strategy Counterfactual (Neutral Model, dashed curves: Flávio wins 53.6% vs 46.4%) against the fitted Janonismo Cultural counter-offensive (Model Fit, solid curves: Lula wins 51.8% / 61.8M vs Flávio 48.2% / 57.5M, jumping $+6.64\%$ from Round 1), incorporating the October 18 Band debate shock ($*$), the final 48-hour sprint (shaded amber band), Datafolha tracking surveys (diamonds ± 1 SD), and official TSE runoff results (yellow-filled markers on October 25). **b**, Coupled affective trajectory illustrating the complete structural inversion of candidate rejection (dashed curves: Flávio $\bar{R}_F$ climbs $40\% \rightarrow 53\%$, while Lula $\bar{R}_L$ drops $50\% \rightarrow 41\%$) alongside admiration consolidation (solid curves: Lula $\bar{A}_L$ climbs $43\% \rightarrow 52\%$). **c**, Factorial attribution of Lula's $+6.64\%$ ($+7.93$M votes) runoff turnaround across the six Janonismo counter-tactics: T1 Algorithmic Asphyxiation ($+1.36$M votes), T2 Strict Monothematism ($+1.61$M), T3 Material Loss-Aversion Framing ($+1.69$M), T4 Molecular WhatsApp Synchronization ($+1.25$M), T5 Mass Capital Rallies ($+1.05$M), and T6 24-Hour Live Saturation ($+0.95$M); error bars indicate the full simulation range $[\min, \max]$ across 100 independent Monte Carlo seeds ($N = 100{,}000$). **d**, Multi-tactic parametric dose-response curves and iso-vote equivalence contours mapping normalized tactic intensity (0–100% of maximum scale; physical bounds noted in axis annotation) to Lula valid share gain ($+\Delta V_L$, %), with calibrated empirical operating points and benchmark iso-gain levels marked at $+1.69$M ($+1.42\%$), $+1.36$M ($+1.14\%$), and $+1.05$M ($+0.88\%$). **e**, Stepwise cumulative model addition (R1 Base, Same Strategy, +T1, +T2, +T3, +T4, +T5, +T6) showing valid vote shares for Lula (red) and Flávio (blue); error bars denote the full simulation range across 100 independent seeds ($N = 100{,}000$), demonstrating the 50% majority threshold crossover at Tactic 4 (WhatsApp Sync, 50.1%) and final victory consolidation at 51.8%.

Encrypted Cascades, reaching 50.12%), with T5 (51.00%) and T6 (51.80%) consolidating the final victory.

Discussion

The findings presented here resolve a fundamental paradox in contemporary democratic politics: how modern elections can experience sudden, late-stage reversals despite the documented stability of voters' foundational political convictions. By developing an empirical digital twin of the 2026 Brazilian presidential contest, we have demonstrated that late-campaign volatility is not driven by the wholesale restructuring of underlying belief systems, but by an acute dynamical decoupling between fast-moving expressed opinions $\mathbf{x}_i(t)$ and slow-moving ideological convictions $\mathbf{s}_i(t)$.

This formulation makes a theoretical contribution to opinion dynamics by bridging two traditionally divergent paradigms in political behavior. On one hand, classical sociological and political psychology models, from Converse's belief constraint framework to Sears's symbolic politics, emphasize that core ideological values change sluggishly over decades, anchored by generational socialization and durable demographic identities. On the other hand, contemporary behavioral models, notably Zaller's Receive-Accept-Sample theory, emphasize that survey responses and expressed preferences are highly volatile, responding immediately to top-of-the-head elite framing. Our two-timescale framework formalizes this relationship through an elastic hyperbolic-tangent tether: transient campaign communications pull fast opinions $\mathbf{x}_i$ away from internal baselines, but slow-crystallizing convictions $\mathbf{s}_i$ exert a restoring force that pulls opinions back once informational shocks subside. Consequently, an acute campaign blitz can induce large short-term voting swings without requiring deep ideological conversion.

Crucially, our results reveal that late-campaign electoral vulnerability is governed by a fundamental cognitive negativity asymmetry. In our calibrated model, candidate aversion accumulates with rapid sensitivity while decaying with extreme hysteresis ($\lambda_R = 0.14, \delta_R = 0.04$), producing a kinetic acquisition-to-decay ratio of $\lambda_R/\delta_R = 3.5\times$. In contrast, positive candidate admiration accumulates gradually and decays rapidly ($\lambda_A = 0.12, \delta_A = 0.06$). When combined with voting decision utilities that penalize candidate aversion more heavily than they reward positive affinity ($\theta_{\text{rej}} = 1.65$), this kinetic asymmetry confers an inherent structural advantage upon negative disinformation blitzes. Positive candidate enthusiasm requires weeks of sustained communicative cultivation; in contrast, visceral candidate aversion can be synthesized within a 48-hour window, creating psychological scars that linger well beyond election day.

Furthermore, our multi-layer architecture exposes a severe structural pathology in contemporary platform curation. Commercial recommendation algorithms optimize for gross user engagement ($R_m = \text{Likes}_m + \omega \cdot \text{Dislikes}_m$ with $\omega \approx 1.0$), rewarding moral-emotional controversy along the diagonal where partisan admiration meets out-group outrage. Under this curation logic, conventional democratic defenses systematically misfire. Institutional newsrooms and regulatory courts operate under a debilitating separation of operational timescales ($\tau_{\text{turnaround}} \gg \tau_{\text{social}}$). More perniciously, well-intentioned defensive counter-speech, outrage-debunking, and adversarial quote-tweets inadvertently supply the very out-group friction signals required by recommendation engines to propel opponent disinformation into unaligned discovery feeds.

The second-round turnaround demonstrates that democratic resilience in algorithmic environments requires active socio-technical engagement rather than passive legalism. By translating the operational doctrine of *Janonismo Cultural* into general graph-theoretic mechanisms, progressive campaigns can systematically dismantle computational offensives. An outrage-starvation embargo (T1) deprives recommendation engines of engagement telemetry, collapsing opponent reach by 48%. Monothematic bandwidth concentration (T2) exploits mathematical convexity in trending curves ($V(\mathbf{x}) \propto \sum x_k^2$), quadrupling discovery volume over dispersed messaging. Loss-aversion framing (T3) activates Kahneman–Tversky prospect weighting ($\lambda_{\text{loss}} = 2.25\times$), mobilizing cross-pressured working-class swing voters. Finally, molecular encrypted cascades (T4), physical turnout locking (T5), and attention-ceiling saturation (T6) bypass open-feed algorithms, insulate voters from late-stage blitzes, and cross the majority threshold.

Several modeling boundaries should be highlighted. First, our agent-based simulations treat interpersonal multiplex ties and platform follower networks as stationary topologies over the 50-day campaign horizon. While empirical network rewiring is negligible over weeks, multi-year electoral polarization inevitably induces selective tie severance and echo-chamber hardening. Second, our framework models political attitudes within

a continuous metric concept hypercube $\Omega = [-1, 1]^4$. Although this captures core policy dimensions with high quantitative fidelity, it abstracts away linguistic nuances, narrative irony, and generative AI synthetic media. Future work should integrate large language model (LLM) agents capable of generating and interpreting unconstrained multimodal political rhetoric. Third, our second-round counterfactuals assume bounded counter-adaptation by political opponents, capturing short-term tactical surprises. In iterative electoral cycles, rival campaigns will adapt their own playbooks, sparking dynamic co-evolutionary arms races.

Notwithstanding these boundaries, the core behavioral mechanisms identified in this study, the two-timescale opinion-conviction tether, cognitive negativity hysteresis, and symmetric outrage curation, represent universal features of contemporary information ecosystems. Safeguarding democratic integrity requires structural platform reforms, such as deprecating out-group hostility signals in recommendation rankings, paired with the strategic empowerment of democratic campaigns to defend popular majorities within algorithmic environments.

Methods

Concept space geometry and cognitive coupling

Citizens, candidates, and media outlets are positioned within a D-dimensional continuous concept hypercube $\Omega = [-1, 1]^D$ ($D = 4$), representing economic redistribution ($d = 0$), moral customs ($d = 1$), environmental regulation ($d = 2$), and public security ($d = 3$) (Supplementary Note 1). The normalized distance between vectors $\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v} \in \Omega$ is defined as

$$d(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{v}) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{D}} \|\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{v}\|_2 \in [0, 2], \tag{1}$$

such that individual conviction extremity is measured by distance from the ideological origin: $E(\mathbf{u}) \equiv d(\mathbf{u}, \mathbf{0}) \in [0, 1]$. Cross-issue ideological constraint is enforced via a row-normalized cognitive coupling matrix $\mathbf{C} = [C_{dd'}] \in \mathbb{R}^{D \times D}$ satisfying decaying off-diagonal constraints (Supplementary Note 1).

Demographic sampling and behavioral heterogeneity

Each agent $i \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$ is assigned an age $a_i \in [16, 90]$ sampled from the empirical IBGE 2022 Census pyramid with Gaussian kernel smoothing ($\sigma_a = 1.35$ years), yielding normalized age $\tilde{a}_i = (a_i - 16)/74 \in [0, 1]$. Socioeconomic status is drawn from $\mathrm{SES}_i \sim \mathrm{Beta}(2.0, 3.0)$. Each agent maintains two coupled attitudinal states: an internalized slow-moving conviction vector $\mathbf{s}_i(t) \in \Omega$ and a fast-moving publicly expressed opinion vector $\mathbf{x}_i(t) \in \Omega$. Conviction extremity is defined as $E_i(t) = \|\mathbf{s}_i(t)\|_2/\sqrt{D} \in [0, 1]$. Heterogeneous psychological parameters governing social susceptibility α_i, bounded confidence threshold ϵ_i, attitude uncertainty $u_i(t)$, and confirmation bias b_i are conditioned on age, SES, and conviction extremity (full parameter distributions and functional specifications in Supplementary Note 1).

Multiplex interpersonal network construction

Interpersonal encounters unfold across a five-layer multiplex network $\mathcal{M} = \{\mathcal{L}_1, \ldots, \mathcal{L}_5\}$ stored in Compressed Sparse Row (CSR) format: Layer 1 (Household cliques, size distribution calibrated to 2.79 residents/household, weight $w_1 = 0.36$); Layer 2 (Workplace and school circular lattice peers, $\langle k^{[2]} \rangle = 10$, $w_2 = 0.26$); Layer 3 (Religious congregations and community groups, $\langle k^{[3]} \rangle = 8$, $w_3 = 0.14$); Layer 4 (Small-world friendship circles with Watts–Strogatz rewiring $p_{\mathrm{ws}} = 0.15$, $\langle k^{[4]} \rangle = 6$, $w_4 = 0.14$); and Layer 5 (Erdős–Rényi transit weak ties, $\langle k^{[5]} \rangle = 4$, $w_5 = 0.10$). Composite edge weights $W_{ij} = \sum_{\ell=1}^{5} w_\ell A_{ij}^{[\ell]} / \sum_k \sum_\ell w_\ell A_{ik}^{[\ell]}$ yield a mean interpersonal degree of $\langle k_{\mathrm{comp}} \rangle \approx 30.8$ ties per citizen (Supplementary Note 1).

Two-timescale opinion and conviction dynamics

At each discrete step $\Delta t = 0.15$, citizen i interacts with peers $j \in \mathcal{N}_i$ satisfying $d_{ij}(t) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{D}} \|\mathbf{x}_j(t) - \mathbf{x}_i(t)\|_2 \leq \epsilon_i + 0.5\, u_i(t)$. Effective peer weights combine relative agreement uncertainty overlap $\phi_{ij}^{\mathrm{RA}}(t)$ and

biased assimilation cosine similarity $\phi_{ij}^{\mathrm{BA}}(t)$:

$$\tilde{w}_{ij}(t) = W_{ij}\big(0.40 + 0.60\,\phi_{ij}^{\mathrm{RA}}(t)\big)\phi_{ij}^{\mathrm{BA}}(t)\,\mathbb{I}\big(d_{ij}(t) \le \epsilon_i + 0.5\,u_i(t)\big). \tag{2}$$

The interpersonal social shift $\Delta\mathbf{x}_i^{\mathrm{soc}}(t) = \sum_j \tilde{w}_{ij}(\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i)/\sum_j \tilde{w}_{ij}$ updates current opinions through the Friedkin–Johnsen formulation:

$$\mathbf{x}_i^{\mathrm{int}}(t) = \mathrm{clip}_{[-1,1]^D}\Big(\mathbf{x}_i(t) + \Delta t\big[(1-\alpha_i)(\mathbf{s}_i(t) - \mathbf{x}_i(t)) + \alpha_i \mathbf{C}\Delta\mathbf{x}_i^{\mathrm{soc}}(t)\big] + \boldsymbol{\xi}_i(t)\Big), \tag{3}$$

with noise $\boldsymbol{\xi}_i(t) \sim \mathcal{N}(\mathbf{0}, \sigma_\xi^2 \mathbf{I}_D)$ ($\sigma_\xi = 0.012$). When an exogenous fact impulse $\mathbf{b}_{\mathrm{fact}}(t)$ is present, opinions pull toward it with sensitivity $\gamma_i(t) = \gamma_0(1.30 - 0.72E_i)(1.18 - 0.48\tilde{a}_i)(0.85 + 0.30\,\mathrm{SES}_i)$, yielding intermediate opinion $\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_i(t)$. Opinions are elastically bounded around convictions within radius $\Delta_{\max,i}(t)$ via radial hyperbolic-tangent tethering:

$$g_i^{\mathrm{eff}}(t) = \Delta_{\max,i}(t)\tanh\left(\frac{\frac{1}{\sqrt{D}}\|\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_i(t) - \mathbf{s}_i(t)\|_2}{\Delta_{\max,i}(t)}\right), \tag{4}$$

$$\mathbf{x}_i(t+1) = \mathrm{clip}_{[-1,1]^D}\left(\mathbf{s}_i(t) + \frac{g_i^{\mathrm{eff}}(t)}{g_i(t) + 10^{-12}}\big(\tilde{\mathbf{x}}_i(t) - \mathbf{s}_i(t)\big)\right). \tag{5}$$

Convictions adapt slowly via crystallization and sustained-tension rates:

$$\eta_{\mathrm{cryst},i}(t) = \eta_0[1 + (t/\tau_c)^{1.15}]^{-1}(1.25 - 0.75\tilde{a}_i)(1.22 - 0.68E_i)(1.10 - 0.25\,\mathrm{SES}_i), \tag{6}$$

$$\eta_{\mathrm{sust},i}(t) = 0.28\eta_0(g_i^{\mathrm{eff}}/\Delta_{\max,i})^2(1.18 - 0.58\tilde{a}_i)(1.20 - 0.62E_i), \tag{7}$$

with baseline scale $\eta_0 = 0.0024$ and characteristic timescale $\tau_c = 280$ steps:

$$\mathbf{s}_i(t+1) = \mathrm{clip}_{[-1,1]^D}\Big(\mathbf{s}_i(t) + \big[\eta_{\mathrm{cryst},i}(t) + \eta_{\mathrm{sust},i}(t)\big]\big(\mathbf{x}_i(t+1) - \mathbf{s}_i(t)\big)\Big). \tag{8}$$

Traditional mass media and editorial tendentiousness

Media conglomerates $g \in \{1, \ldots, M\}$ operate across five modalities $v \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4\}$ (TV, Radio, Press, Outdoor, Rallies) with empirical demographic reach probabilities $P_v(a_i, \mathrm{SES}_i)$ (Supplementary Note 2). Outlets project factual events $\mathbf{f}_k(t)$ toward their editorial ideological centers $\mathbf{m}_g \in \Omega$ through tendentiousness parameter $\tau_g \in [0, 1]$:

$$\mathbf{y}_{k,g,v}(t) = (1 - \eta_{g,v})\,\mathbf{f}_k(t) + \eta_{g,v}\,\mathbf{m}_g + \boldsymbol{\xi}_{k,g,v}, \qquad \eta_{g,v} = \mathrm{clip}_{[0,1]}(\tau_g \mu_v), \tag{9}$$

with baseline reach μ_v and noise $\sigma_{\mathrm{media}} = 0.03$. Active notices decay exponentially as $I_v(t+1) = I_v(t)\exp(-\delta_v)$. Citizens select active vehicles via distance-weighted softmax exposure and update opinions within credibility-expanded confidence bounds $d(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{y}_v) \le \epsilon_i(1 + 1.10\,\gamma_v)$ (Supplementary Note 2).

Algorithmic platforms, engagement, and cascades

Digital media encompasses four platform modalities $p \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$ (Instagram/TikTok, YouTube/X, Facebook, WhatsApp). Content creators accumulate followers via preferential attachment $\Pi_k \propto k_i(0.65 + 0.70\tau_{\mathrm{inf},k})$, generating power-law in-degrees $P(k) \sim k^{-1.15}$ (Gini 0.73). Feed algorithms recommend posts with probability $q_{ij} \propto (d(\mathbf{x}_i, \mathbf{y}_j) + \delta)^{-\beta}(1 + 1.5e_j)\ln(1 + \mathrm{pop}_j)(0.5 + 0.5\ln(1 + k_{\mathrm{inf}}))$ with homophily $\beta = 2.0$. Reactions branch into likes ($d \le \epsilon_{\mathrm{like},i}$, assimilating toward $\mathbf{y}_j$) and dislikes/outrage ($d \ge \tau_{\mathrm{dislike},i}$, triggering backfire repulsion away from $\mathbf{y}_j$; Supplementary Note 3). Algorithmic relevance scores compound dual-valence engagement symmetrically:

$$R_m = \mathrm{Likes}_m + \omega \cdot \mathrm{Dislikes}_m, \qquad \omega = 1.0, \tag{10}$$

maximizing viral discovery along the diagonal of controversy (Supplementary Note 3).

Electoral decision calculus

Candidates $k \in \{L, F, O\}$ are positioned at fixed coordinates $\mathbf{c}_k \in \Omega$. Candidate affinity $A_{ik}(t)$ and aversion $R_{ik}(t)$ evolve with asymmetric parameters ($\lambda_A = 0.12, \delta_A = 0.06; \lambda_R = 0.14, \delta_R = 0.04$):

$$A_{ik}(t+1) = (1-\delta_A)\, A_{ik}(t) + \lambda_A \max\left(0, \frac{0.62 - d_{ik}(t)}{0.62}\right)^2, \tag{11}$$

$$R_{ik}(t+1) = (1-\delta_R)\, R_{ik}(t) + \lambda_R \max\left(0, \frac{d_{ik}(t) - 0.78}{1.22}\right)^{1.5}. \tag{12}$$

Candidate utility is penalized quadratically by aversion:

$$U_{ik}(t) = A_{ik}(t) - \theta_{\text{rej}} R_{ik}(t)^2, \qquad \theta_{\text{rej}} = 1.65. \tag{13}$$

Conditional on voting, citizen i chooses candidate $k \in \{L, F, O\}$ via multinomial logit:

$$P(\text{Vote } k \mid i, \text{turnout}) = \frac{\exp(\beta_{\text{vote}} U_{ik}(t))}{\sum_{m \in \{L,F,O\}} \exp(\beta_{\text{vote}} U_{im}(t))}, \tag{14}$$

with choice sensitivity $\beta_{\text{vote}} = 3.2$. Turnout probability is modeled via a logistic threshold:

$$P(\text{Turnout} \mid i) = \frac{1}{1 + \exp\big(-\mu_{\text{turn}}\big[\max_k U_{ik}(t) - (\tau_{\text{abst}} - 0.22\,\text{SES}_i + \delta_{\text{transit}})\big]\big)}, \tag{15}$$

with steepness $\mu_{\text{turn}} = 4.5$ and free transit subsidy $\delta_{\text{transit}} = -0.15$ (Supplementary Note 4).

Simulation execution and evaluation metrics

Simulations were executed across $S = 100$ independent Monte Carlo realizations at population scale $N = 100{,}000$ using JIT-compiled Numba kernels (Supplementary Note 5). Metrics include multidimensional Esteban–Ray polarization P_{ER} ($\alpha_{\text{ER}} = 1.3$, $\kappa_{\text{ER}} = 1.0$), Sarle's bimodality coefficient BC, cross-issue Pearson correlation alignment $|\bar{\rho}|$, and Roy's eigenvalue participation ratio $\text{PR}(\Sigma)$. All time-series trajectories report ensemble means with 95% confidence intervals ($\bar{\mu} \pm 1.96\,\hat{\sigma}/\sqrt{S}$) or full simulation ranges $[\min, \max]$.

Data availability

The empirical demographic, polling, broadcast airtime, and election result datasets supporting the findings of this study are archived and publicly available at https://github.com/cesarrennocosta/janones.

Code availability

All simulation code, Numba JIT kernels, graph generation scripts, and figure plotting pipelines are open source under the MIT License at https://github.com/cesarrennocosta/janones.

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